Praise of the Twelve Deeds

Dvīdaśakāra nāma nayastotraṃ · Toh 1135 · Derge Tengyur
མདོད་པ་བཅུགྱེས་ཀྱི་ཚུལ་ལ་བསྟོད་པ

The Praise of the Twelve Deeds, called in Tibetan Dzepa Chunyi kyi Tsul la Töpa and given in its Sanskrit title line as Dvīdaśakāra Nāma Nayastotra, is a short devotional hymn that its colophon attributes to the great master, the noble Nāgārjuna. It is Toh 1135 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the Praises (stotra) section, the collection of hymns that opens the Tengyur. Addressed to the Buddha Śākyamuni, its verses celebrate in turn the deeds of his final life, from his descent from the realm of the gods and entry into Queen Māyā's womb, through his birth in the Lumbinī grove, his youth, his renunciation, his austerities and his awakening beneath the Bodhi tree, to his turning of the wheel of Dharma, his victory over opponents, the great miracles at Śrāvastī, his passing into nirvāṇa at Kuśinagara, and the division of his relics. Nearly every verse closes with a line of homage, and the hymn ends by dedicating its merit so that the conduct of all beings may come to equal that of the Buddha himself.

In the Indian language: dvīdaśakāra nāma nayastotraṃ
In the Tibetan language: Praise of the Twelve Deeds

Homage to the Buddha Śākyamuni.

You who first aroused the mind of awakening,
Who perfected the two accumulations of merit and wisdom,
And who in this age, through vast deeds, became
The protector of beings: to you I offer praise.

Having tamed the gods, and knowing the time for taming had come,
You descended from the realm of the gods and came in the guise of an elephant;
Having surveyed the family lines, you entered the womb
Of Queen Māyā: homage to you!

When ten months were complete and the son of the Śākyas
Was born in the auspicious grove of Lumbinī,
You of the supreme marks, to whom Brahmā and Śakra (Indra) bowed,
Were confirmed as one of the lineage of awakening: homage to you!

As a youth, that mighty lion among men
Displayed his skill in the arts in Aṅga and Magadha;

Having vanquished those who were arrogant,
You stood unrivaled: homage to you!

To act in keeping with the ways of the world
And to avoid reproach, you kept a retinue
Of queens, and, skilled in means,
You ruled the kingdom: homage to you!

Seeing that the affairs of saṃsāra have no essence,
You left your home and even traveled through the sky,
And before the Pure Stūpa, you yourself, upon yourself,
Conferred the going forth: homage to you!

Intending to accomplish awakening through effort,
For six years on the bank of the Nairañjanā
You practiced austerities, and, having brought diligence to its culmination,
You attained the supreme meditative concentration: homage to you!

So that your striving since beginningless time might bear fruit,
Beneath the Bodhi tree in Magadha,
Seated unmoving with legs crossed, you became a fully awakened buddha
And brought awakening to perfection: homage to you!

Swiftly regarding beings with compassion,
At Vārāṇasī and other supreme places
You turned the wheel of Dharma, and those to be tamed
You established in the three vehicles: homage to you!

Having crushed the wicked challenges of others,
The six non-Buddhist teachers, Devadatta, and the rest,
In the land called Circle Breaker you tamed the māras:
Homage to you, the Sage victorious in battle!

Through qualities unequaled in the three realms of existence,
In Śrāvastī you displayed the great miracles;
Highly honored by gods, humans, and all beings,
You made the teaching flourish: homage to you!

In order to swiftly rouse the lazy,
On the pure ground of Kuśinagara
You dissolved your deathless body, which is like a vajra,
And passed into nirvāṇa: homage to you!

Because in truth there is no destruction,
And so that beings of the future might gain merit,
In that very place you emanated many relics
And made your remains into eight portions: homage to you!

Thus, by this brief praise of the manner of the deeds
Of the Blessed One, the lord of the teaching,
Through its virtue may the conduct of all beings, too,
Become equal to the conduct of the Sugata (the Buddha) himself.

The Praise of the Twelve Deeds, composed by the great master, the noble Nāgārjuna, is complete.

Translator's Notes

• The place where the māras were tamed is given as 'khor mo 'jig; it cannot be identified with confidence, so the name is translated literally as "Circle Breaker." The "Pure Stūpa" (mchod rten rnam dag) is the stūpa before which, in Tibetan tellings of the life, the Bodhisattva cut his hair and ordained himself; since its Sanskrit name is uncertain, it is rendered by meaning.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.